

Tropicbirds

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Phaethontiformes
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	3

All three species of tropicbird have elongated tail streamers; slender bodies; and long, pointed wings, giving great aerial efficiency. They can remain far offshore over the sea almost

indefinitely, soaring high over the waves. On land, they merely shuffle on short, weak legs. Nests are often hidden in rock cavities or vegetation, in loose colonies on remote tropical islands.



RED-BILLED TROPICBIRD
The serrated edges of this bird's bill helps it grasp slippery, muscular fish.

Phaethon aethereus

Red-billed tropicbird



Location E. Pacific, C. Atlantic, and N. Indian oceans

Length 31–32 in (78–81 cm)
Weight 21–29 oz (600–825 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern



Although it is a poor swimmer, spending little time on the water, this highly aerial seabird is often found hundreds of miles from land. It feeds by plunge-diving, sometimes from a considerable height, to catch squid and fish, especially

flying fish. An elegant bird, with silky white, pink-flushed plumage, it has extremely long tail streamers that it switches from side to side in an elaborate, airborne courtship display. The red-billed tropicbird is one of only 3 species in its family, all restricted to the tropics.



Storks

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Ciconiiformes
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	19

Storks are tall, upstanding, long-striding birds with daggerlike bills for catching small prey or tearing meat from carcasses. Although big and heavy, they excel in the air, having long, broad wings with upcurved, deeply “fingered” feathers that reduce turbulence at the wingtip, helping them soar on rising currents.

WHITE STORK
These birds build huge nests, which a pair will reuse year after year.



Leptoptilos crumenifer

Marabou stork

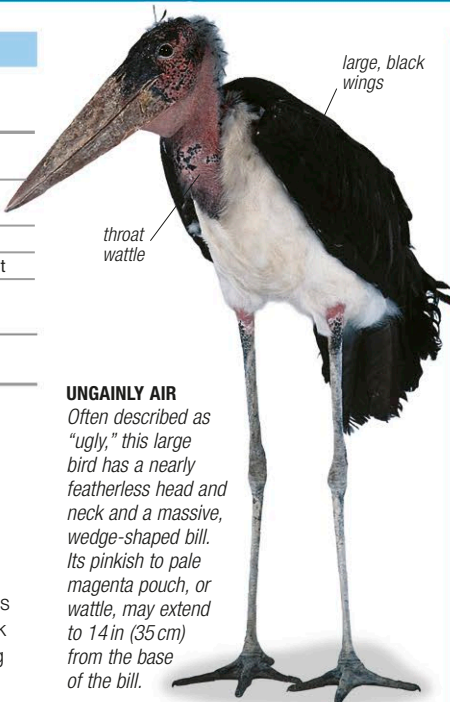


Location Africa (south of Sahara)

Height 4 ft (1.2 m)
Weight 11–17 lb (5–7.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



This huge, ungainly looking stork is slaty gray, black, and white, and has a wingspan of nearly 9¾ft (3 m), one of the largest of any land bird. Its elegant, soaring flight contrasts markedly with its hunched and unappealing aspect when on the ground. Because of its feeding habits (see panel below), the marabou stork has done very well, and is increasing in numbers throughout its range.



UNGAINLY AIR
Often described as “ugly,” this large bird has a nearly featherless head and neck and a massive, wedge-shaped bill. Its pinkish to pale magenta pouch, or wattle, may extend to 14 in (35 cm) from the base of the bill.

large, black wings

throat wattle



SCAVENGING

Although it is a stork, the marabou often behaves more like a vulture. It soars high up in search of food, and uses its large beak to tear rotting meat from carcasses. Like a true vulture, it has an almost featherless head and neck—an adaptation that helps to prevent it from getting soiled with blood and gore when it inserts its head in carrion.

Mycteria americana

Wood stork



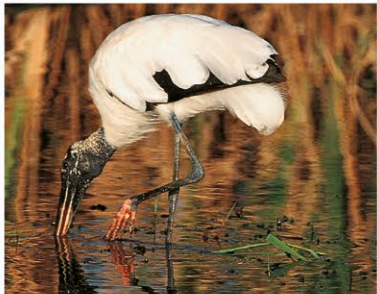
Location North, Central, and South America, Caribbean

Height 34–43 in (85–110 cm)
Weight 5½ lb (2.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern



The wood stork locates food by both sight and touch, enabling it to feed by day or night, and in murky water. The scaly head and neck are bald. While feeding by touch, the bird walks through the water with its long, thick bill

open, moving it from side to side. White, with black wingtips, it has a dark gray head and neck. The wood stork feeds either alone or in groups, and breeds colonially, building a nest often over water at treetop level, and very occasionally on the ground where there are no ground predators.



Ciconia ciconia

White stork



Location Europe, Africa, Asia

Height 3¼–4¼ ft (1–1.3 m)
Weight 5½ lb (2.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern



In parts of Northern Europe, this elegant, black and white bird is a harbinger of spring, migrating from as far away as southern Africa, where it spends the

winter. Today, largely due to habitat change, far fewer storks breed in Northern Europe, but their rooftop nests are still considered good luck. The white stork feeds primarily in shallow water and grassland, but also at the edges of crop fields. It migrates mainly over land, where thermals help its soaring flight.

